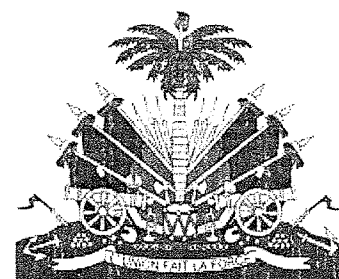


History of Haiti

1492-1805



1492-1697 · 1750-1784 · 1788-1790 · 1790-1791 · 1791 · 1791-1792 · 1792-1796 · 1796-1801 · 1801-1802 · 1802-1803 · 1804-1805

Haitian Revolution Begins

August–September 1791

21-28 Oct 1790



The Ogé Rebellion: Jacques Vincent Ogé, an affranchis representing the colony in France, leads a revolt against the white colonial authorities in Saint-Domingue. Despite colonists' attempts to prevent him from leaving France, Ogé manages to escape to England, where he is secretly helped by abolitionists. From there he sails to the United States, where he buys weaponry before arriving in Saint-Domingue on October 21. Eluding police, Ogé manages to unite with friends and family and organize a "common front of gens de couleur against the forces of white supremacy." He amasses 300 men, consisting primarily of mulattoes and some free blacks. The group, fully armed, marches to Grande-Rivière, just south of Le Cap, and joins with others with the intention of taking the city and disarming the white population. The colonists manage to disband Ogé's army by outnumbering the rebels. Ogé escapes and goes into hiding in the eastern part of the island in Spanish Santo Domingo.

14 August 1791

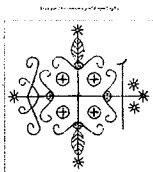
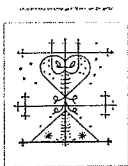
The Haitian Revolution begins with the Bois Caïman ceremony. Ready to carry out their plans, the slaves meet in Morne-Rouge to make final preparations and to give instructions. The slaves decide that "Upon a given signal, the plantations would be systematically set aflame, and a generalized slave insurrection set afoot." Rumors circulate that white masters and colonial authorities are on their way to France to fight the Crown's recent decrees granting mulattoes and free blacks rights. Though false, these rumors "served as a rallying point around which to galvanize the aspirations of the slaves, to solidify and channel these into open rebellion."

The Bois Caïman ceremony and subsequent insurrections are the result of months of planning and strategizing. There are two hundred slave leaders involved from around the North. All hold privileged positions on their plantations, most of them commandeurs with influence and authority over other slaves. Through strategic maneuvering these leaders successfully unite a vast network of Africans, mulattoes, maroons, commandeurs, house slaves, field slaves, and free blacks.

The Bois Caïman ceremony takes place in a thickly wooded area where the slaves solemnize their pact in a voodoo ritual. The ceremony is officiated by Boukman, a maroon leader and voodoo priest from Jamaica, and a voodoo high priestess. Various accounts from that night describe a tempestuous storm, animal sacrifices, and voodoo deities. However, over the centuries the ceremony has become legendary, and it is important to note it can be difficult to distill fact from myth. Some historians, for example, believe the ceremony took place on the 22nd of August, not the 14th.

A Note on Voodoo

"Voodoo, both a sacred dance and a religion, was expressly forbidden in the French colonies, and from the very beginning, the colonists tried in vain to crush it." Voodoo prevailed despite the whites' efforts, nurtured in secret



by the colony's first slaves. During European colonialism and the Haitian revolution Voodoo played a singular role for slaves:

"Despite rigid prohibitions, voodoo was indeed one of the few areas of totally autonomous activity for the African slaves. As a religion and a vital spiritual force, it was a source of psychological liberation in that it enabled them to express and reaffirm that self-existence they objectively recognized through their own labor . . . Voodoo further enabled the

slaves to break away psychologically from the very real and concrete chains of slavery and to see themselves as independent beings; in short it gave them a sense of human dignity and enabled them to survive."

During the revolution Voodoo brought together disparate forces in the colony, uniting various rebel factions to fight side by side. In the 19th and 20th centuries, Voodoo was widely misunderstood in the rest of the world. Hollywood portrayed the religion as primitive and savage, ignoring its rich history and complexity. Many researchers have misunderstood its relationship with Catholicism, which has masked and at times fused with Voodoo as it has developed over the centuries.

Voodoo today is still a significant part of most Haitians' daily lives. A Haitian woman in the 20th century said that "The loa love us, protect us and watch over us. They show us what is happening to our relatives living far away, and they tell us what medicines will do us good when we are sick."

16 August 1791

Slaves in the Limbé district stray from the leaders' plan, apparently due to a misunderstanding, and are caught setting fire to an estate. During their interrogation they reveal the conspiracy and the names of the leaders.

Interestingly, though, many of the planters who are warned of the rebellion stand by their slaves and refuse to believe the rumors. One plantation manager, for example, "offered his own head in exchange if the denunciations....proved true." Other planters, warned of the coming violence, escaped with their lives but still couldn't protect their property, often losing everything.

The other slaves involved in the conspiracy prepare to move ahead with the rebellion as planned, vowing to "to burn le Cap, the plantations, and to massacre the whites all at the same time."

22 August 1791

The slaves launch their insurrection in the North. That night Boukman and his forces march throughout the region, taking prisoners and killing whites. By midnight, plantations are in flames and the revolt has begun. Armed with torches, guns, sabers, and makeshift weapons the rebels continue their devastation as they go from plantation to plantation. By six the next morning, only a few slaves in the area have yet to join Boukman, and scores of plantations and their owners are destroyed.

The group, numbering 1,000 to 2,000, next splits into smaller bands to attack designated plantations, demonstrating their highly organized strategy. As the revolt in the North grows "awesome in dimensions," whites become anxious about defending Le Cap, where the colonial government is centralized. It is to Le Cap – the social and cultural hub of the colony – that whites flee their burning plantations and rebelling slaves. Later an interrogated slave would declare that "in every workshop in the city there were negroes concerned in the plot." The whites and slaves both realize that controlling the city would be critical in determining the revolution's outcome.

Blanchelande writes that "Fears of a conspiracy [in Le Cap] were confirmed as we had successfully discovered and continue daily to discover plots that prove that the revolt is combined between the slaves of the city and those of the plains; we have therefore established permanent surveillance to prevent the first sign of fire here in the city which would soon develop into a general conflagration."

23 August 1791

The slaves march to the Limbé district, adding to their forces. The group moves from plantation to plantation, seizing control and establishing military camps. Along the way more slaves join the rebellion, and those who don't are cut down mercilessly.

By the end of the day, "the finest sugar plantations of Saint Domingue were literally devoured by flames." A horrified colonist wrote that "one can count as many rebel camps as there were plantations."

24 August 1791

The slaves continue west to Port-Margot in the early evening, hitting at least four plantations.

25 August 1791

The rebels march to Le Cap, after burning down the region's largest plantations and killing scores of whites. Every entrance to the city is guarded, and the slaves march against the whites' cannons and guns, meeting armed resistance for the first time. Though the whites manage to drive the slaves back, the rebels divide up and regroup, returning by two different routes to successfully seize the city.

The slaves hold out for three weeks against the planters, who are badly armed, disorganized, injured, and desperately in need of help. The slaves' strategy is clear: every time the planters circle or overcome them, the slaves retreat to the mountains to reorganize and prepare a new attack.

At the same time, slaves in the northeast rise up, "torch in hand, with equal coordination and purpose," and advanced "like wildfire." The slaves burn down the plantations methodically until all the major parishes in the upper North Plain region are hit and communication between them is severed.

30-31 Aug 1791

The slave forces reach nearly 15,000. Slaves join because they "had deserted their plantations, by will or by force, or by the sheer thrust and compulsion of events purposefully set in motion by the activities of a revolutionary core." They are transformed from fugitive slaves into "hardened, armed rebel, fighting for freedom," a mental and physical process "accelerated by collective rebellion in a context of revolutionary social and political upheaval."

A colonist writes that "We had learned . . . that a large attack was afoot, but how could we ever have known that there reigned among these men, so numerous and formerly so passive, such a concerted accord that everything was carried out exactly as was declared? . . . The revolt had been too sudden, too vast and too well-planned for it to seem possible to stop it or even to moderate its ravages."

The planters are able to protect Le Cap but cannot save their plantations. They send frantic requests for military aid to Santo Domingo, Cuba, Jamaica, and the United States to no avail. Within 8 days the rebels devastate 184 sugar plantations in the north, losing planters millions of French livres. By September all the plantations within fifty miles of Le Cap are destroyed.

8 September 1791

The revolution spreads, becoming more militant and organized. On the plantations it takes less to incite riots. Plantation crops are ruined as entire fields of slaves desert or simply stop working. In the "magnificent" Plaine-des-Cayes, comprising of almost 100 sugar plantations, every single plantation is destroyed. Many of the planters, "financially and morally ruined," are desperate to save their fortunes while others consider themselves fortunate "just to get out of this wretched colony with their lives and a shirt on their backs."

The white troops are completely unprepared for the rebel's guerrilla tactics, which include surprise attacks, thefts of supplies and livestock, ambushes, and poisoned arrows. The slaves, more resilient than the whites, are merciless, taking no prisoners of war. Over half of the 6,000 troops from France have at this point already "perished from the ravages of a tropical climate and endemic sicknesses reaching epidemic proportions."

An army volunteer writes: "This is the graveyard of the French; here one dies off like flies."

Mid-Sept 1791

Slaves continue to make demands, but with the entire colonial system at stake, the planters can't concede.

One colonist writes presciently of the colonists' dilemma in negotiating with the slaves: "For, if we reward with freedom those who have burned our plantations and massacred our people, the slaves who have hitherto remained loyal will do likewise in order to receive the same benefit. Then nothing more can be said: the whites must perish."

Another states "There can be no agriculture in Saint Domingue without slavery; we did not go to fetch half a million savage slaves off the coast of Africa to bring them to the colony as French citizens."

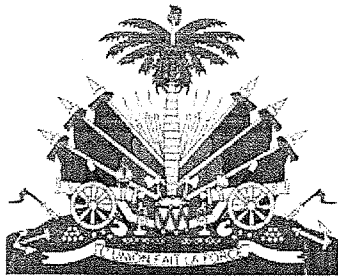
21 Sept 1791

The Colonial Assembly at Saint Marc recognizes the May 15 decree and grants citizenship to mulattoes and free blacks. White planters object violently and tensions in the colony rise.

[< BACK | HISTORY OF HAITI home | NEXT >](#)

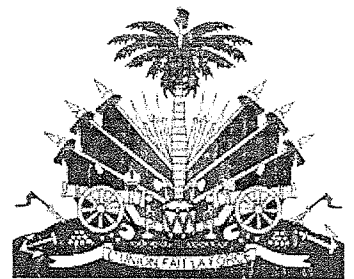
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History of Haiti

1492-1805



1492-1697 · 1750-1784 · 1788-1790 · 1790-1791 · 1791 · 1791-1792 · 1792-1796 · 1796-1801 · 1801-1802 · 1802-1803 · 1804-1805

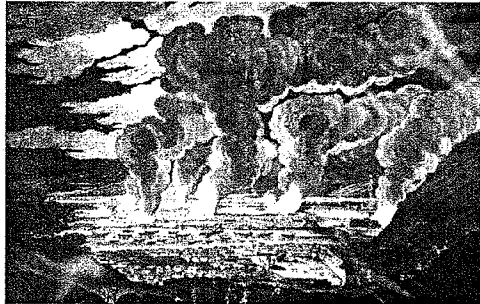
The Revolution Builds

1791-1792

24 September 1791

The National Assembly in France revokes the May 15 decree, which had granted limited rights to free blacks and mulattoes, and names three commissioners to restore order in Saint-Domingue. In response, mulatto agitation in the South becomes open, armed rebellion in collaboration with the black slaves. Rebels in the west seize Port-au-Prince capital, cut its water supply and block all access to incoming food supplies before they are overcome by the French troops.

26 September 1791



Le Cap is burned to the ground by rebelling slaves.

"During those first weeks of revolution, the slaves destroyed the whites and their property with much the same ruthlessness and cruelty that they had suffered for so many years at the hands of their masters. The scenes of horror and bloodshed on the plantations, as whites hopelessly tried to defend themselves or, at best, to flee from the unleashed terror and rage of their former slaves, were only too reminiscent of the brutality that the slaves themselves had endured under the plantations

regime. Yet as atrocious as they were, these acts of vengeance were surprisingly moderate, in the opinion of one of the best-known historians of that revolution, compared with the cold-blooded, grotesque savagery and sadistically calculated torture committed by their oppressors throughout the past. These were impassioned acts of revenge, of retribution, and were relatively short-lived."

The "horrible carnage" gives way to strategic military operations, tactical maneuvers and new political alliances as the slaves gain territory and stabilize their positions. They raid plantations for military equipment, loot the whites' forces after they are repelled, and trade with the Spanish for weaponry.

28 September 1791

The National Assembly in France issues a decree granting amnesty to all free persons in Saint Domingue charged with "acts of revolution." The slaves however are still intent on continuing warfare and pursuing "an end to the whites."

October 1791



Port-au-Prince is burned to the ground during fighting between whites and mulattoes.

Toussaint Louverture, a young former slave, begins to gain recognition as a promising leader in the rebel army.

November 1791

Of 170,000 slaves in the North Province, 80,000 have by now joined the rebel forces. The slaves set up camps in Platons with thousands of dwellings, two infirmaries, a civil government, crops and food supplies.

The three new civil commissioners named in September arrive in the colony from France.

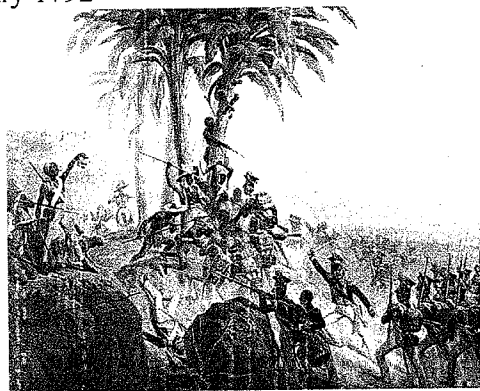
November 1791

Boukman is killed in battle, becoming the first of the original leaders to die. His head is cut off by colonists and exposed on a stake in Le Cap with the inscription "The head of Boukman, leader of the rebels." In response, the slaves mourn intensely, retreating into the mountains to hold services. Fervor builds amongst the rank-and-file soldiers to kill every white they see, including all their prisoners. The grief and rage is finally channeled into a three day calenda ceremony.

Without Boukman, the rebel leaders falter, unsure of how to proceed. Against the wishes of their troops, they choose to negotiate with the colonists, asking for improved quality of life on plantations in exchange for the release of prisoners, namely the leaders' wives. The slave troops, on the other hand, vow that they will continue fighting for freedom, even if it means killing their own leaders. They, more than their commanders, are violently opposed to compromising or returning to the plantations and realize that the negotiations are doomed.

At the end of the month, the Colonial Assembly refuses all the slaves' demands. The rebel leaders agree to return to war.

9 January 1792



Governor Blanchelande marches against the slaves encamped at Platons. The rebel army, out of supplies and outnumbered, abandons camp and retreats to the mountains. They leave behind noncombatants, consisting of a few hundred women, children, elderly and infirm, whom they expect will be treated leniently by the French. Instead the troops massacre them, "their heads cut off and their bodies slashed to pieces as the women fought ferociously to protect their children." About 3,000 other captured slaves are returned to masters, and many are killed to set an example. The colonists celebrate their victory, but in reality the core of the insurgent movement – including its strongest, most determined, leaders – is still in hiding.

22–23 January 1792

Slaves begin their attack to recapture the Quinaminthe district in the northeast of Saint-Domingue, attacking Le Cap to secure ammunition and replenish their supplies.

4 April 1792

Louis XVI affirms the Jacobin decree, granting equal political rights to free blacks and mulattoes in Saint-Domingue. A second commission is assembled, led by Léger Félicité Sonthonax, to enforce the ruling.

**The year marks the three hundred year anniversary of Columbus' landing on Hispaniola.*

May 1792

Spain declares war against England, then France. In Saint-Domingue, the European powers battle for control of the lucrative colony.

20 June 1792

Blacks and mulattoes in the South ally with the British and begin an open rebellion.

In Le Cap, civil commissioners Blanchelande and Sonthonax flee for protection as rebels attack the city. Every street becomes a battlefield: "Terror and panic spread like wildfire as the women and children desperately tried to escape; atrocities and pillaging were committed on both sides."

21 June 1792

Over 10,000 slaves in Le Cap are now in open revolt. Threatened on all sides, French colonists realize that they need the slaves' support to keep control of Saint-Domingue. Civil commissioners issue a proclamation guaranteeing freedom and the full rights of French citizenship to all slaves who join them to defend France from foreign and domestic enemies. Though some leaders refuse, allying instead with the Spanish, a group of marooned slaves answers the call, descending upon the capital "like an avalanche," and forces the invaders to retreat. Chaos

reigns, as nearly the entire city burns down and white colonists fight each other. In the coming months Spain, England and France are to battle constantly for Saint-Domingue.

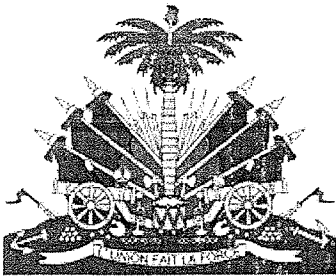
17 September 1792

Civil commissioner Étienne Polverel arrives from France and the slaves offer to negotiate with the colonists once more. Polverel refuses to meet their demands but does agree to grant an unconditional pardon if the slaves surrender. The colonists protest angrily to this concession, and Polverel, like Blanchelande before him, is forced to attack the slaves in response to the pressure.

[< BACK](#) | [HISTORY OF HAïti home](#) | [NEXT >](#)

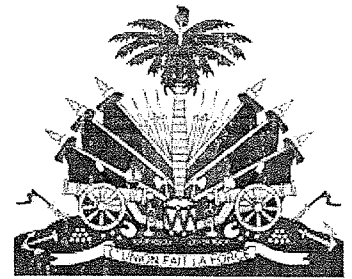
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History of Haiti

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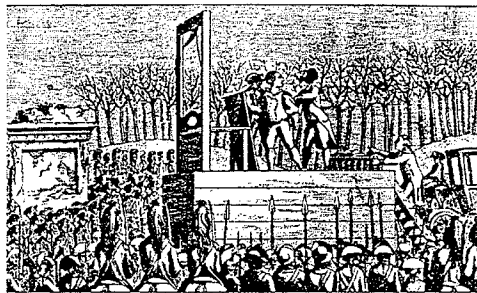


1492-1697 · 1750-1784 · 1788-1790 · 1790-1791 · 1791 · 1791-1792 · 1792-1796 · 1796-1801 · 1801-1802 · 1802-1803 · 1804-1805

Upheavals in France and Saint-Domingue

1792-1796

21 Sept 1792



In France, The Republic is declared, abolishing the monarchy. In January of the following year Louis XVI is beheaded.

21 October 1792

Vicomte de Rochambeau is appointed Governor General of Saint-Domingue.

February 1793

Rebel leaders, including Toussaint Louverture, join Spanish forces to fight against the French.

France declares war on England and Holland.

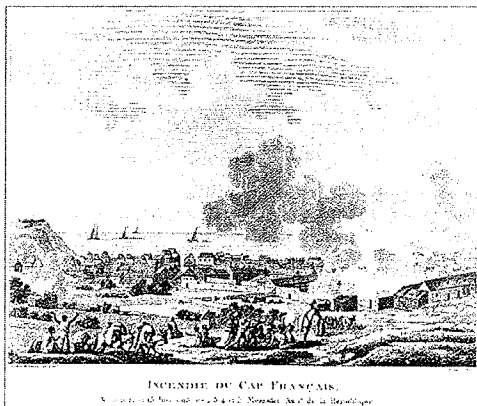
10-13 March 1793

The Reign of Terror sweeps through France after royalist uprisings and military reverses. Tens of thousands of opponents of the Revolution are executed along with common criminals.

Early June 1793

Louverture offers to aid General Laveaux, Chief Commander of the republican forces in the North. Louverture offers his support and 5,000-6,000 troops in exchange for full amnesty and general emancipation. Laveaux refuses and Louverture continues to aid the Spanish for another full year.

20 June 1793



Le Cap is again consumed by flames and deserted by white residents. 10,000 white refugees fleeing the destruction arrive in the United States fleeing the destruction.

The French continue to court the support of the rebel troops. A new decree is issued proclaiming that any slave wishing to join republican army will be granted his freedom. Soon after the offer is extended to troops' wives and children.

27 August 1793

Polverel declares that the certain slaves are now free, specifically those on sequestered plantations in the West, those belonging to émigré planters and deportees, all remaining insurgent maroons, and all those who are fighting for France. Though Poverel believes in gradually granting slaves their rights, Sonthonax is simultaneously

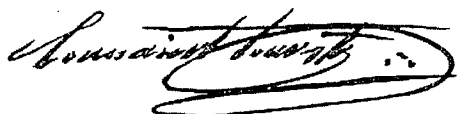
planning far more radical action in the North.

29 August 1793

Sonthonax issues a General Emancipation decree abolishing slavery in the North. More slaves in the colony have their freedom than ever before. Monsieur Artaud, one of the colony's wealthiest planters with more than 1,000 slaves, tells Sonthonax that "only universal freedom could spare the whites from being totally annihilated."

Following decrees further restrict punishments and grant minimal pay to slaves – now called "laborers" – in the colony. Skilled laborers are legally allowed on administrative councils. However, the declarations of freedom are bound solely to theoretical property rights. Slaves are still regulated by the government, legally bound to the same plantations and masters. Their daily lives change little. In protest, many slaves go on strike, arriving to the fields late, leaving early, and doing little work. Disarmed, many former rebels turn to vagrancy as their main form of resistance. Notably, women demand that they are granted equal pay and rights as men. Under the current system women are held to the same rules and punishments but paid only two thirds of men's wages.

August 1793



Toussaint Louverture makes his historic speech to rally the blacks, signifying that the revolution lives on.

20 September 1793

British troops sever ties between the North and South, isolating the provinces from each other as the Europeans, planters and rebels all fight for control. The British intend to restore order, make Saint-Domingue a British colony, and reinstate slavery.

21 August 1793

The first anniversary of the French Republic. Civil commissioner Polverel, combining the principles of the French Revolution with those of general emancipation, gives the slaves on his plantation their freedom. He then invites planters in the West to follow his example. The planters, pressured by Polverel and their slaves, back down and emancipate many of their slaves.

September 1793

A series of national reforms sweep through France from September 1793 through October 1795. The measures include the abolition of colonial slavery, economic measures to aid the poor, and support for public education.

4 February 1794

The Convention officially abolishes in France and French territories, including Saint-Domingue.

7 February 1794

A new work code is promulgated. Among other things, it requires owners to give slaves a third of plantation revenue and an additional free day. Slaves' daily lives are still largely unaffected, however, and the new code fails to ease their discontent. Widespread resistance continues, with many slaves appropriating abandoned land for themselves.

Despite the force of the slave revolution, most colonists are still unaware that the system in Saint-Domingue is slowly breaking down. They do note however that "Unanimous and uncompetitive, the black values his liberty only to the extent that it affords him the possibility of living according to his own philosophy." They also realize that Polverel's version of emancipation, in which little actually changes on the plantations, is unacceptable to the laborers and incompatible with their values.

Land Ownership



Land ownership in Saint-Domingue was a critical issue before, during, and after the Haitian Revolution. Land ownership granted access to power and prosperity and was sought after by all of the colony's social classes.

During the build up to the revolution whites were increasingly threatened by the mulattoes and free blacks who were becoming powerful landowners. At the beginning of the revolution, one of the slaves' central demands was to have small plots of land and an additional free day during the week to cultivate them. Later on, during Louverture's reign, laborers objected to his adherence to a plantation-based economy which required blacks to work land that was not theirs.

Through the course of the revolution, and in the years following, former slaves felt owning land was critical in order to truly claim their freedom. To that end they fought for the colonists – and even their own leaders – for land rights, never giving up their goal to own the fields they worked in.

Spring 1794

France has lost control of nearly the entire colony, aside from Le Cap and Port-de-Paix. The British and Spanish control most of the North, Môle St. Nicolas in the West, and Jérémie and Grand-Anse in the South. Many mulattoes and blacks are aiding the foreign forces with the goal of expelling the French.

April-May 1794

The civil commissioners from France are forced to depart. André Rigaud, a mulatto military leader, consolidates the colony's authority in the South. After these changes, there is a period of relative peace, with markedly fewer protest movements from black laborers.

6 May 1794

Louverture abandons the Spanish army in the east and joins with the French forces after the Spanish refuse to take steps to end slavery. His chief officers would eventually become some of the best-known leaders of the revolution, including Jean-Jacques Dessalines, Henri Christophe, and his nephew Moïse.

4 June 1794

The British capture Port-au-Prince led by General Thomas Maitland. British troops occupy most major seaports in the west and south. Spanish troops, along with a number of former slaves, occupy much of the western provinces.

25 June 1794



The French legislature recalls commissioners Polverel and Sonthonax. Sonthonax later is tried and triumphantly acquitted of the charges of treason brought against him by colonists.

Nearly 4 months after Polverel's departure, Rigaud writes to him: "*The [South] province . . . is tranquil and in a reasonably good state of defense . . . Work is going well; your proclamations on agricultural production are having the full effect that you anticipated.*"

Late 1794

Various maroon bands disband and join with Louverture's forces. A few months later, Louverture and Rigaud along with other military leaders begin launching simultaneous attacks against the British. In June of 1795, after five months of fighting, Louverture takes control of Mirebelais, northeast of Port-au-Prince in the center of the colony.

22 July 1795

France and Spain sign a peace treaty ceding Saint Domingue to France after months of battle. The agreement is ratified the following year in the Treaty of Basel.

26 October 1795

The National Convention in France dissolves and the Directory is established. The Directory sends five new civil commissioners to Saint-Domingue "to survey the administration and application of French law in the colony, to keep Saint Domingue 'both French and free,' and to restore its economic prosperity based on a system of general emancipation in what had by now become, at least nominally, a multiracial, egalitarian society." Mulatto rights and the abolition of slavery are now considered "accomplished facts."

20 March 1796

Louverture establishes that he is the strongest leader in the colony when Governor General Laveaux returns to Le Cap from Port-de-Paix. Laveaux attempts to reins in the mulattoes, who he believes have been abusing their new rights, and frees blacks from the prisons. Mulattoes, threatened by his new policies and association with Louverture, charge Laveaux with tyranny and begin mobilizing forces against him. The situation climaxes when a group of mulattoes arrest Laveaux and throw him in prison, where he is kept until Louverture orders his release.

The incident demonstrates a shift in power and solidifies Louverture's position. Not only powerful, "Toussaint appeared to hold the undivided confidence of the black masses." Laveaux is forced to proclaim Louverture Lieutenant Governor of the colony. Meanwhile, class and race-based power struggles continue to simmer throughout Saint-Domingue.

11 May



Three new civil commissioners from France, including Sonthonax, arrive in Saint-Domingue.

June 1796

Final withdrawal of Spanish forces from Hispaniola per the peace treaty signed by France and Spain in July 1795.

18 July 1796



Rochambeau is dismissed as Governor General after clashing with Sonthonax and returns to France. Rigaud replaces him.

[< BACK](#) | [HISTORY OF HAIti home](#) | [NEXT >](#)

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